Naaja Nathanielsen

(nathan-EEL-sen)

Minister of Industry, Raw Materials, Mining, Energy, Law Enforcement, and Equality
Government of Greenland

Addressed as: **Honorable Minister** | Office held since: **April 2025**

Naaja Nathanielsen represents a new generation of Greenlandic leadership, balancing indigenous rights, environmental protection, and development without compromising her principles.

- **Developing Greenland**
  Nathanielsen is focused on expanding Greenland's economy through sustainable development that benefits local communities. She insists that “mining must benefit the local region and the population as a whole."

- **Standing Her Ground**
  Nathanielsen follows her moral compass, cancelling projects or banning exploration when she believes it is a bad deal for Greenland. She briefly left politics when she disagreed with her political party’s decisionmaking process.

Nathanielsen is a quick study, assuming responsibility for a significant number of ministerial portfolios in a short political career. These include business, energy, finance, gender equality, housing, infrastructure, justice, law enforcement, energy, and mining.

WHY THEY MATTER

Nathanielsen is at the center of a geopolitical storm, defending Greenland's right to determine its own future while navigating intense international interest in its critical mineral deposits.

- **Leading the Sovereignty Defense**
  Since President Trump’s renewed push to acquire Greenland, Nathanielsen has been a vocal opponent. She has said that "everything is on the table except [our] sovereignty" and they are “not going to accept our future development of our mineral sector to be decided outside Greenland.”

- **Welcoming Foreign Investment**
  Nathanielsen is enthusiastic about foreign investment. She stresses that the reform agenda is anchored in “legal predictability, macroeconomic stability, and investor confidence.”

Nathanielsen is open to developing new resources. She has touted glacial rock flour, in which silt is crushed to nano-particles by the weight of the retreating ice sheet, and anorthosite as a sustainable source of aluminum.

MEETING WITH THEM

While professional and serious, Nathanielsen employs a conversational style focused on developing rapport and connection. She remains firm about Greenland's interests and requirements.

- **Dedicated to Greenland**
  Nathanielsen is an unabashed believer in her nation and its vital role in the green transition. At the same time, she has stressed that it is a shared global responsibility to be a good steward of Greenland's resources.

- **Sensitive to Tradeoffs**
  The Minister recognizes there is no simple answer to advance her agenda, noting that "when you do make decisions you cannot make everybody happy so when you have a sustainability agenda there will be groups and people who will be affected negatively."

Nathanielsen is personable, using humor to lighten up formal gatherings, warning her dog may bark during a Zoom call or acknowledging it may be difficult to hold the audience's attention ahead of cocktail hour. She breaks out in a sly smile when she is amused by comments made by counterparts.

ON THEIR MIND

- **Danish Snap Elections**
  Denmark's Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen has called an early election on 24 March to take advantage of a "Greenland bounce" after Donald Trump's threats to invade the Arctic territory.

- **Siumut Party Withdraws**
  Siumut party has withdrawn from the coalition government after Nathanielsen and another minister announced candidacies for Denmark's parliamentary election. Foreign Minister Vivian Motzfeldt, who has played a key role in diplomatic talks with the United States, will leave her post as a result.

- **Technical Cooperation Agreement with France**
  Greenland has signed a technical cooperation agreement with France aimed at improving geological knowledge of the Arctic island's mineral resources. French satellite technology will map ice-free areas of Greenland's vast coastline and collect data on the country's subsurface.

- **Denmark Rejects U.S. Plan to Send Hospital Boat**
  Denmark's defense minister in late February rejected a plan by President Trump to send a "great hospital boat" to Greenland. The Danish government had not been made aware of the plan and said there was "no need for special health care efforts" in Greenland.

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NETWORK

Nathanielsen pairs a hard line against U.S. efforts to pressure or annex Greenland with a pragmatic willingness to accept foreign investment and deepen ties with Europe.

She has been a vocal critic of the U.S. president, saying Greenlanders feel “betrayed by a great partner.” Yet she has kept the door open to American capital, including through talks with the U.S. Export-Import Bank about potential financing for projects such as the Tanbreez rare earth mine, while also courting Europe and arguing that Greenland is ready to help secure its raw materials future.

Nathanielsen continues to prove her political staying power, keeping her place in government under Prime Minister Jens-Frederik Nielsen despite Inuit Ataqatigiit (IA)’s third-place finish in the March 2025 election and an earlier brief rift with the party.

After leaving politics in 2016 over what she called a lack of consultation, Nathanielsen returned to government in 2021 and seems to have resolved her dispute with former IA leader Sara Olsvig. Nathanielsen has told local press that the “break has been healing for years.”

CONTROVERSIES

Nathanielsen has encountered repeated criticism as she navigates the tensions between fostering economic development while preserving Greenland’s fragile ecosystem. Her decision to run for a seat in the Danish Parliament also is roiling Greenlandic politics.

- **Policy Disputes**
  Her decision to ban uranium mining and revoke certain mining licenses has drawn criticism from industry stakeholders and some opposition politicians who argue these moves deter foreign investment. Nathanielsen acknowledges that her party’s unpopular fishery reforms contributed to IA dropping from 12 to 7 seats in the March 2025 election

- **Political Ambitions**
  Nathanielsen's decision to run for Denmark's parliament (Folketing) while remaining in her ministerial post triggered a coalition crisis. She has argued that it is essential to have experienced Greenlandic voices in Copenhagen to ensure the Kingdom of Denmark remains a firm barrier against outside acquisition.

Nathanielsen regularly finds herself in spats with Siumut, a Greenlandic political party which historically has supported more aggressive resource exploitation. Siumut has criticized Nathanielsen for making premature promises without securing necessary approvals, and recently departed the coalition government due to her decision to run for a seat in the Danish Parliament.

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CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **Minister of Industry, Raw Materials, Mining, Energy, Law Enforcement, and Equality,** Government of Greenland (2025 to present)
- **Minister of Business, Trade, Mineral Resources, Justice, and Gender Equality**, Government of Greenland (2023 to 2025)
- **Minister of Finance, Minerals, Justice, and Gender Equality**, Government of Greenland (2021 to 2023)
- **Minister of Housing, Infrastructure, Justice, and Gender Equality**, Government of Greenland (2021)
- **Director**, Department of Prisons and Probation (2016 to 2021)
- **Member,** Inatsisartut (Greenland Parliament) (2009 to 2016)

BIO

Nathanielsen's upbringing in the remote town of Taslilaq has informed her pride in Greenland's heritage and her understanding of local communities' needs. Born on December 6, 1975, she has expressed concern over the division between "real Greenlanders" and those who speak Danish, calling it a form of racism. She also has advocated for "humane prisons" to rehabilitate Greenlandic convicts.

- **Studying Psychology**
  Nathanielsen holds a master's degree in psychology from the University of Copenhagen, and she has published articles on forensic psychiatry patients, services, and legislation in Greenland, as well as suicide attempts by forensic psychiatry patients.
- **Promoting Gender Equality**
  Nathanielsen has introduced bills to implement gender quotes and comprehensive gender equality. Plus, she backed Greenland's investigation into the Danish government's birth control scheme during the 1960s and 1970s, known as the spiral or coil scandal.

Nathanielsen is married with two children, and is a dog owner. The Minister's Instagram account is filled with visits to museums, plays, and concerts (including Coldplay and Harry Styles). She also posts about her urban gardening skills. She speaks Greenlandic, Danish, and English.

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